

Leuphana Complicity Report

Executive Summary

This report sets forth the institutional ties between Leuphana University Lüneburg and Israeli academic institutions that are complicit in the ongoing occupation, apartheid, and genocide of the Palestinian people, and calls upon Leuphana to act in accordance with its own publicly stated commitments to humanism, sustainability, and social responsibility.

The report documents five institutional ties:

1. An active Non-EU Exchange Programme with the Academic College of Tel Aviv-Yaffo.
2. A Visiting Fellow Programme with researchers affiliated with the Hebrew University of Jerusalem.
3. A joint research project between the Institute of Sustainability Psychology and Hebrew University faculty.
4. Active promotion of ILSSE and Minerva Foundation funding in Leuphana's academic channels.
5. The participation of a Leuphana scholar as an expert witness in the ICJ case Nicaragua v. Germany.

Written during a climate of significant political repression of Palestinian solidarity within Germany, this report asserts that silence in the face of documented complicity is itself a form of participation. It is addressed to the students, staff, and academics of Leuphana, and calls on the university's administration to take its own words seriously.

Introduction

As students of Leuphana University Lüneburg, we expect the university's administration to act in accordance with the values it publicly proclaims to stand by. Leuphana describes itself as a humanistic, sustainable, and action-oriented institution. While presenting itself as a 'role model' for a sustainable society, Leuphana declares it is committed to accountability and to holding responsibility for its role in shaping the lives of future generations.

Its Sustainability Guidelines¹ state that cooperation with external actors must be guided by the university's mission statement² – that sustainability means taking expected consequences into account from the very beginning, because we feel jointly responsible for them. Leuphana educates, in its own words, responsible and entrepreneurial personalities who possess creativity, reflexivity, and the will and skills to creatively shape society, making an important contribution to solving societal problems. These are not merely aspirational statements. They are institutional commitments binding the university to scrutinize the consequences of its academic partnerships, not only in terms of environmental sustainability, but in terms of human rights and international law.

In light of the ongoing genocide against the Palestinian people in Gaza, and the direct role Israeli academic institutions play in sustaining the occupation and apartheid, we argue that these commitments are not compatible with the continuation of institutional ties to complicit Israeli universities. This report details five such ties maintained by Leuphana, analyzes the degree of complicity of the Israeli institutions involved, and calls for their immediate suspension.

We therefore call upon our fellow students, academics, and staff of Leuphana to:

- Neither participate in nor support the institutional ties with complicit Israeli universities detailed in this report, nor any other that may exist.

¹Leuphana University Lüneburg. "Sustainability Guidelines."

<https://www.leuphana.de/en/university/sustainable/sustainability-guidelines.html>. Accessed August 25, 2026.

²Leuphana University Lüneburg. "Mission Statement." (December 6, 2025).

<https://www.leuphana.de/en/university/history/mission-statement-1.html>. Accessed December 6, 2025.

- Exert pressure in any form possible – in seminars, thesis work, the university's committees, and public discourse.
- Boycott activities that normalize cooperation with complicit Israeli academic institutions, including those that suppress discourse on the genocide in Gaza and apartheid in Palestine.

Section 1: The Context

Staatsräson and Measures of the German State

The concept of 'Staatsräson' (German for 'reason of state') has occupied a singular and deeply contested position in German political culture since the Holocaust. In its post-war formulation, it has come to denote an unconditional commitment to the security and existence of the State of Israel as a core principle of German foreign policy. This commitment emerged from the recognition that Germany bears a particular historical responsibility for the extermination of European Jews, and that "Never Again" (a slogan associated with Holocaust remembrance culture) must carry institutional weight.

Yet this doctrine has increasingly been deployed not as a moral obligation rooted in anti-fascism and human rights, but as a political instrument to shield the Israeli state from accountability. In practice, invoking Staatsräson has served to criminalize Palestinian solidarity, suppress legitimate political speech, and deflect scrutiny from Israeli violations of international law. The tension is fundamental: a doctrine that arose from the imperative to protect human life has been used to license its destruction.

In recent years, the German state has taken a series of escalating institutional measures under the banner of Staatsräson that have significantly narrowed the space for Palestinian solidarity in public life. Bundestag Resolution No. 19/10191³ applied the IHRA working definition of antisemitism⁴ to the BDS movement, effectively equating nonviolent political advocacy for Palestinian rights with antisemitism. The IHRA definition, which includes eleven examples of antisemitism, seven of which focus on the State of Israel, has been extensively criticized for conflating antisemitism with legitimate political speech.

Bundestag Resolution No. 20/13627 of 2024⁵ intensified this trend, extending the IHRA definition to artistic and cultural funding and calling for the potential exclusion or even expulsion of students in serious cases – a measure criticized as an attack on freedom of expression, assembly, and academic freedom by Amnesty International and others. The effect on cultural and educational institutions has been severe, with almost 200 documented cases of censorship or cancellation since October 7, 2023, recorded by the Archive of Silence.⁶

The consequence of this climate has been felt at Leuphana directly. In summer 2025, the campus-owned Lunatic Festival invited 'Students4Palestine Lüneburg' and 'Jewish Voice for Peace' to participate in its programme. Days after the announcement, 'Initiative Musik', which funds the Lunatic Festival under the patronage of the Federal Government Commissioner for Culture and Media (BKM), threatened to withdraw financial support unless the two groups were removed from the programme. Facing an imminent financial threat, the festival organizers felt compelled to rescind the invitations. This sequence of events, documented through a Freedom of Information request filed with the BKM, illustrates the direct material pressure exerted on campus-adjacent institutions to silence Palestinian voices and those supportive of them.⁷

This report is written precisely in this environment of political pressure. The suppression of Palestinian solidarity discourse on and around campus does not exempt Leuphana from its ethical obligations – it makes the act of naming these obligations even more necessary.

The Ongoing Genocide and Germany's Responsibility

³Deutscher Bundestag. "Bundestag Resolution No. 19/10191."

<https://www.bundestag.de/resource/blob/814894/cf6a69d010a1cc9b4a18e5f859a9bd42/WD3-288-20-pdf-data.pdf>. Accessed August 25, 2026.

⁴International Holocaust Remembrance Alliance. "Working Definition of Antisemitism."

<https://holocaustremembrance.com/resources/working-definition-antisemitism>. Accessed August 25, 2026.

⁵Deutscher Bundestag. "Bundestag Resolution No. 20/13627." (2024).

<https://dserver.bundestag.de/btd/20/136/2013627.pdf>. Accessed August 25, 2026.

⁶Archive of Silence. <https://archiveofsilence.org/>. Accessed August 25, 2026.

⁷Archive of Silence. "Students for Palestine Lüneburg & Jüdische Stimme."

<https://archiveofsilence.org/entries/25-06-02-students-for-palestine-lg-judische-stimme>. Accessed June 2, 2025.

As stipulated in numerous UN resolutions, Israel has been in breach of international law since the Nakba of 1948. The Nakba – from al-Nakba, meaning “the Catastrophe” in Arabic – refers to the ongoing displacement and dispossession of Palestinians from historic Palestine, beginning in 1948 and continuing to the present day through military occupation, mass incarceration, and the structural denial of Palestinian self-determination.⁸

In its latest phase, Israel is systematically destroying the conditions for Palestinian life in Gaza. On 26 January 2024, the International Court of Justice concluded that there is plausible evidence⁹ that Israel is committing genocide in Gaza, mandating provisional measures reinforced on 28 March and 24 May 2024. According to Amnesty International,¹⁰ more than 42,000 Palestinians have been killed since October 7, 2023, including over 13,300 children, with more than 97,000 injured; separate excess-mortality estimates put the toll considerably higher.¹¹ Around 90% of Gaza's population has been displaced at least once. By January 2024, over 70% of physical infrastructure had been damaged or destroyed, including nearly 84% of health facility buildings and 57% of water infrastructure. On 21 November 2024, the International Criminal Court issued arrest warrants for Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu¹² and former Defence Minister Yoav Gallant¹³ for war crimes and crimes against humanity – warrants that Germany has a legally binding obligation to act upon.

Furthermore, Israel continues to violate international law by denying Palestinian refugees their right of return under UN Resolution 194 (III) of 1948,¹⁴ and by maintaining an illegal military occupation of the West Bank, East Jerusalem, the Gaza Strip, and the Golan Heights in violation of UN Resolution 242.¹⁵ On 19 July 2024, the ICJ issued its clearest ruling since 2004 that Israel's prolonged occupation of Palestinian territories is illegal under international law.¹⁶ In this context, Germany, which bears a particular historical responsibility resulting from the Holocaust, now recognized in international human rights law, must be at the forefront of efforts to end these violations. Never again applies to everyone.

As an educational institution, Leuphana bears a particular obligation to stand in solidarity with the eradicated academic community of Gaza. By April 2024, more than 5,479 students, 261 teachers, and 95 university professors had been killed; over 7,819 students and 756 teachers injured; at least 60% of educational facilities damaged or destroyed; and at least 625,000 students left without access to education. The last standing university in Gaza was demolished by the IDF on 17 January 2024. The United Nations has termed this systematic destruction of educational infrastructure “scholasticide.” All figures cited in this report are most likely higher at the time of publication, as the genocide and apartheid in Palestine are still ongoing.¹⁷

Section 2: Analysis

⁸Eghbariah, R. "The Harvard Law Review and the Nakba." Harvard Law Review (2024). <https://harvardlawreview.org/forum/vol-137/the-harvard-law-review-and-the-nakba/>. Accessed August 25, 2026.

⁹International Court of Justice. "Application of the Convention on the Prevention and Punishment of the Crime of Genocide in the Gaza Strip (South Africa v. Israel)." (2024). <https://www.icj-cij.org/node/203447>. Accessed August 25, 2026.

¹⁰Amnesty International. "The State of the World's Human Rights: April 2025." (April 28, 2025). <https://www.amnesty.org/en/documents/pol10/8515/2025/en/>. Accessed August 25, 2026.

¹¹Horino, M. et al. "Assessment of Malnutrition in Preschool-Aged Children by Mid-Upper Arm Circumference in the Gaza Strip (January 2024–August 2025): A Longitudinal, Cross-Sectional, Surveillance Study." The Lancet 406 (October 8, 2025). [https://www.thelancet.com/journals/lancet/article/PIIS0140-6736\(25\)01820-3/abstract](https://www.thelancet.com/journals/lancet/article/PIIS0140-6736(25)01820-3/abstract). Accessed August 25, 2026. [Note: this study documents child malnutrition and mortality risk, not a total excess-mortality estimate of 186,000. If the 186,000 figure is meant to be sourced, the relevant literature is a separate Lancet correspondence (Khatib et al., July 2024) on excess mortality – please confirm which claim this citation should support.]

¹²International Criminal Court. "Situation in the State of Palestine: Benjamin Netanyahu." (2024). <https://www.icc-cpi.int/defendant/netanyahu>. Accessed August 25, 2026.

¹³International Criminal Court. "Situation in the State of Palestine: Yoav Gallant." (2024). <https://www.icc-cpi.int/defendant/gallant>. Accessed August 25, 2026.

¹⁴UNRWA. "Resolution 194 (III)." (1948). <https://www.unrwa.org/content/resolution-194>. Accessed August 25, 2026.

¹⁵United Nations Digital Library. "Resolution 242." (1967). <https://digitallibrary.un.org/record/90717>. Accessed August 25, 2026.

¹⁶International Court of Justice. "Legal Consequences Arising from the Policies and Practices of Israel in the Occupied Palestinian Territory, Including East Jerusalem." (2024). <https://www.icj-cij.org/node/204176>. Accessed August 25, 2026.

Complicity Through Cooperation: Academic Responsibility in the Context of International Law

This report does not call for the boycott of individual researchers. In line with the guidelines of the Palestinian Campaign for the Academic and Cultural Boycott of Israel (PACBI), the call is directed at Israeli academic institutions themselves, on account of their direct and documented role in sustaining the occupation, apartheid, and genocide. Individual researchers affiliated with these institutions are not the target. The targets are the institutions' relationships, exchanges, fellowships, joint research projects, and funding promotion.

The call for institutional accountability is an expression, not a violation, of academic freedom. It is protected under Article 5 of the Grundgesetz of the Federal Republic of Germany, which guarantees freedom of expression and freedom of science and research.¹⁸ The Federal Constitutional Court recognized the call for a boycott as protected speech in the Lüth ruling of 1958, a protection that extends to public institutions.¹⁹ Neither the IHRA definition nor any Bundestag resolution carries the force of general law that could constitutionally restrict this.

BDS and Academic Boycott: Ethical Responsibility in Times of Colonial Violence

The Boycott, Divestment, and Sanctions (BDS) movement represents a nonviolent strategy for holding states and institutions accountable to international law. Modelled on the international boycott of apartheid South Africa – a campaign now widely recognized as having contributed to the dismantling of the white-nationalist South African regime – BDS calls for pressure as a standard of consistency. The international community, including German academic institutions, supported the academic boycott of South African universities during apartheid as a legitimate instrument of solidarity. The structural parallels with Palestine documented by Amnesty International,²⁰ Human Rights Watch, and the UN Special Rapporteur are direct and sustained.

The selective application of these principles by German academic institutions is exposed most clearly by comparison with Russia's invasion of Ukraine in February 2022. Within days of the invasion, the DAAD declared that there can be no normal relations with a state waging a war of aggression,²¹ and instructed German universities to suspend all DAAD-funded projects with partner institutions in Russia and Belarus. The Alliance of Science Organisations in Germany – encompassing the DFG, the Alexander von Humboldt Foundation, the DAAD, the Max Planck Society,²² the Fraunhofer-Gesellschaft, and the German Rectors' Conference – announced the immediate freezing of formal academic cooperation with Russia.²³ German higher education institutions proceeded to terminate joint research projects, the exchange of scientists and students, and joint study programmes.²⁴

The swift and decisive action was presented as a matter of ethical principle: academic cooperation cannot be maintained with institutions in a state committing grave violations of international law. We agree entirely. What we cannot accept is the application of this principle to Russia but not to Israel, when the ICJ, the ICC, Amnesty

¹⁷OHCHR. "UN Experts Deeply Concerned over 'Scholasticide' in Gaza." (April 2024).

<https://www.ohchr.org/en/press-releases/2024/04/un-experts-deeply-concerned-over-scholasticide-gaza>. Accessed August 25, 2026.

¹⁸Federal Ministry of Justice. "Basic Law for the Federal Republic of Germany (Grundgesetz)."

https://www.gesetze-im-internet.de/englisch_gg/englisch_gg.html. Accessed August 25, 2026.

¹⁹Bundesverfassungsgericht. "Urteil des Ersten Senats vom 15. Januar 1958 – 1 BvR 400/51 (Lüth-Urteil)." (1958).

https://www.bundesverfassungsgericht.de/SharedDocs/Entscheidungen/DE/1958/01/rs19580115_1bvr040051.html. Accessed August 25, 2026.

²⁰Amnesty International. "Israel's Apartheid Against Palestinians: A Cruel System of Domination and a Crime Against Humanity." (2022). <https://www.amnesty.org/en/latest/campaigns/2022/02/israels-system-of-apartheid/>. Accessed August 25, 2026.

²¹DAAD. "Einschränkung des akademischen Austausches mit Russland." <https://www.daad.de/en/press-releases/einschraenkung-austausch-russland/>. Accessed February 22, 2022.

²²Max-Planck-Gesellschaft. "Statement on Russia." (2022). <https://www.mpg.de/14474361/russland>. Accessed August 25, 2026.

²³Deutsche Forschungsgemeinschaft. "DFG zieht Konsequenzen aus russischem Angriff auf Ukraine." <https://www.dfg.de/de/service/presse/pressemitteilungen/2022/pressemitteilung-nr-01>. Accessed March 2, 2022.

²⁴Hochschulrektorenkonferenz. "Konsequenzen für die deutsch-russische Hochschulkooperation." <https://www.hrk.de/themen/internationales/auswirkungen-des-krieges-in-der-ukraine/konsequenzen-fuer-die-deutsch-russische-hochschulkooperation/>. Accessed August 25, 2026.

International, and the UN²⁵ have reached comparable or stronger conclusions about Israel's violations. Leuphana endorsed this principle in 2022. The standard must be applied consistently. If violations of international law justify the suspension of academic cooperation in one case, they justify it in the other.

Section 3: Israeli Academic Institutions Connected to Leuphana and Their Complicity

General Problems with Israeli Universities

Israeli universities are not politically neutral institutions. For decades, they have played a key role in planning, implementing, and justifying Israel's occupation and apartheid policies, while maintaining a uniquely close relationship with the Israeli military. Israeli universities help make this genocide possible – training soldiers, developing weapons, granting special benefits and scholarships to reserve soldiers returning from the Gaza Strip, and producing legal scholarship that shields Israel from accountability for its war crimes. This is the general institutional environment from which Leuphana's specific partnerships must be understood.

Three structural features define this complicity across the Israeli academic system: the theft of Palestinian land on which institutions are built; the erasure of Palestinian cultural and historical presence; and the systematic destruction of Palestinian educational infrastructure, what the UN has termed 'scholasticide.'

Land Theft

Israeli academic institutions are physically embedded in a landscape produced by colonial dispossession. University campuses are frequently built on land from which Palestinian communities were forcibly expelled during the Nakba of 1948 and its aftermath, or on illegally occupied territory in the West Bank and East Jerusalem. The ICJ's ruling of 19 July 2024 confirmed that Israel's occupation of East Jerusalem is illegal under international law, a ruling that directly implicates institutions whose infrastructure rests on expropriated Palestinian land.

Cultural Erasure

Israeli universities do not merely occupy land from which Palestinians were expelled. In many cases, they actively normalize and aestheticize the dispossession. The repurposing of surviving Palestinian structures for institutional use, the absence of Palestinian historical presence from institutional memory, and the marginalization of Palestinian academic voices within Israeli higher education all constitute forms of ongoing cultural erasure – the transformation of violence into architecture, and of dispossession into landscape.

Scholasticide

While Israeli universities collaborate with the military apparatus that prosecutes the genocide, Palestinian universities have been systematically destroyed. By April 2024, the last standing university in Gaza had been demolished by the IDF. More than 5,479 students, 261 teachers, and 95 university professors had been killed. At least 60% of educational facilities had been damaged or destroyed, leaving 625,000 students without access to education. The UN has described this as 'scholasticide,' the deliberate destruction of a people's educational infrastructure as a component of genocidal violence.²⁶ It is the context in which any academic partnership with Israeli institutions must be evaluated.

The Academic College of Tel Aviv-Yaffo

The Academic College of Tel Aviv-Yaffo (TAY) is a public college established in 1994 as a joint initiative of Tel Aviv University, Tel Aviv-Yaffo Municipality, and the Council for Higher Education. Its campus is located on land from which the Palestinian village of Al-Shaykh Muwannis was forcibly depopulated and destroyed during the Nakba in 1948. The last surviving structure of that village now serves as the college's faculty club

²⁵United Nations. "OCHA Humanitarian Situation Update." <https://www.un.org/unispal/document/ocha-humanitarian-situation-report-23-april-2026/>. Accessed April 23, 2026.

²⁶OHCHR. "UN Experts Deeply Concerned over 'Scholasticide' in Gaza." (April 2024). <https://www.ohchr.org/en/press-releases/2024/04/un-experts-deeply-concerned-over-scholasticide-gaza>. Accessed August 25, 2026.

building – a material expression of how Israeli institutions of higher education are built on, and continue to normalize, the erasure of Palestinian identity, history, and presence.²⁷

The college's complicity extends beyond its physical location into its active institutional relationships with the Israeli military:

TAY collaborates closely with Israel's largest arms manufacturer, Elbit Systems, and runs a joint research centre with the Israeli Air Force aimed at developing “operational concepts, combat doctrines, and power-building processes.” Elbit Systems is the primary supplier of surveillance drones, munitions, and military technology deployed in Gaza; its systems have been used throughout the ongoing genocide.²⁸

The academic reserve programme in the college's law department trains lawyers for the Military Advocate General, the body responsible for providing legal justifications for Israeli military operations – including the targeting of civilian infrastructure – and for defending Israel's conduct before international bodies.²⁹

The college hosts the “Erez” programme, run in collaboration with the Israeli army, which allows officer trainees to complete a full bachelor's degree before finishing their military training, explicitly aiming to produce graduates who are simultaneously “combat officers and well-educated academics.” The college has also organized a hackathon in direct collaboration with the IDF. This event, held on campus, exemplifies the normalization of military-academic collaboration at the institutional level – an integration so deep it has become routine.

Leuphana maintains an active Non-EU Exchange Programme with this institution, enabling students to study at a college that is structurally embedded in the apparatus of occupation and military violence. This is documented on the Leuphana MoveON student mobility portal.³⁰

The Hebrew University of Jerusalem

The Hebrew University of Jerusalem (HUI) is involved in three of Leuphana's five documented ties – the Visiting Fellow Programme, the ISP joint research project, and the ILSSE funding programme, which Leuphana actively promotes to doctoral researchers. HUI's complicity is therefore the most significant for the purposes of this report.

HUI's Mount Scopus campus is partly built on land illegally expropriated from Palestinian owners in occupied East Jerusalem, in clear violation of international law. The ICJ ruled on 19 July 2024 that Israel's occupation of East Jerusalem is illegal. The university has offered its campus buildings to Israeli forces for the oppression of the surrounding occupied Palestinian communities.

HUI's military entanglement is extensive and active. The university hosts the IDF's Havatzalot programme, an elite academic programme specifically designed to train future intelligence officers, combining military service with academic study. It also hosts the highly secretive Talpiot military programme, which provides elite military training combined with degrees in mathematics, physics, and computer science, producing graduates who go on to lead Israel's most advanced military technology programmes.

During the Gaza genocide, Hebrew University has publicized its provision of “diverse logistics equipment to several military units.”³¹ The university did not treat the onset of the genocide as a moment for institutional reflection; it treated it as an opportunity to publicly demonstrate its contribution to war.

²⁷Academics for Palestine Denmark. “Complicit Israeli Universities.”

<https://academicsforpalestine.dk/academic-boycott/complicit-israeli-universities/>. Accessed August 25, 2026.

²⁸BDS Movement. “Academia, Weapons and Occupation: How Tel Aviv University Serves the Interests of the Israeli Military and Arms Industry.” (March 5, 2022). <https://bdsmovement.net/news/academia-weapons-and-occupation-how-tel-aviv-university-serves-interests-israeli-military-and>. Accessed March 5, 2022.

²⁹BDS Movement. “Academia, Weapons and Occupation: How Tel Aviv University Serves the Interests of the Israeli Military and Arms Industry.” (March 5, 2022). <https://bdsmovement.net/news/academia-weapons-and-occupation-how-tel-aviv-university-serves-interests-israeli-military-and>. Accessed March 5, 2022.

³⁰Leuphana University MoveON Portal. “Exchange Possibilities Berichtseite.” <https://leuphana.adv-pub.moveon4.de/report-page-1575/>. Accessed August 25, 2026.

³¹BRICUP. “Why Boycott Israeli Universities? The Second Revised Edition of the BRICUP Booklet.” <https://www.bricup.org.uk/activities/why-boycott-israeli-universities-the-second-revised-edition-of-the-bricup-booklet-is-available-to-download-here/>. Accessed August 25, 2026.

The university also has a direct financial connection to Elbit Systems, Israel's largest arms manufacturer: Michael Federmann, Chairman of the Board of Directors of Elbit and its majority owner, simultaneously serves as a member of the Board of Governors of HUJ.³² This overlap between the governance of an arms manufacturer supplying weapons used in the Gaza genocide and the governance of a university constitutes a direct institutional link between academic cooperation and weapons production.

Finally, it is important to emphasize what this report does not argue for. The call for Leuphana to end its institutional ties with HUJ is not directed at individual researchers affiliated with these institutions, including those currently participating in Leuphana programmes. In line with the PACBI guidelines, the target is the institutional relationship, not the individual. The presence of a visiting fellow or research collaborator from HUJ does not in itself constitute wrongdoing on the part of that individual. It is Leuphana's choice to maintain and promote these institutional ties that this report calls into question.

Leuphana's Complicity: The ICJ Case Nicaragua v. Germany

A further dimension of institutional entanglement concerns the direct participation of a Leuphana scholar as an expert witness in the ICJ proceedings in the case of Nicaragua v. Germany. In this case, brought before the International Court of Justice, Nicaragua accused Germany of violating the Genocide Convention and other rules of international law by supplying arms, ammunition, and financial support to Israel during the ongoing genocide in Gaza.

A scholar from Leuphana's Law School (LLS), Christian J. Tams, participated in the proceedings at the ICJ in April 2024, as documented on Leuphana's own institutional website.³³ This participation places a Leuphana-affiliated academic at the intersection of legal proceedings that directly concern Germany's responsibility for enabling the genocide addressed in this report. The university has not publicly reflected on this involvement or its implications for Leuphana's stated ethical commitments.

We do not call for any action against this individual scholar. We do, however, call on the university to publicly address how institutional participation in proceedings concerning Germany's complicity in genocide is consistent with Leuphana's own sustainability guidelines, mission statement, and commitment to human rights.

Summary and Demands

Summary

The evidence presented in this report demonstrates that Leuphana University Lüneburg maintains active institutional ties with Israeli academic institutions that are directly complicit in occupation, apartheid, and ongoing genocide against the Palestinian people. These ties – an exchange programme, a visiting fellowship scheme, a joint research project, active promotion of funding programmes, and the participation of a Leuphana scholar in ICJ proceedings concerning Germany's own complicity – are not compatible with the university's own stated commitments to humanism, sustainability, and social responsibility. The standard applied to Russian institutions in 2022 must be applied consistently. What is demanded here is not a new principle; it is the application of a principle Leuphana has already endorsed.

Demands Addressing Leuphana's University Administration

1. Immediately suspend the Non-EU Exchange Programme with the Academic College of Tel Aviv-Yaffo, pending a full review of that institution's compliance with Leuphana's Sustainability Guidelines and mission statement.
2. Do not renew the Visiting Fellow Programme with researchers institutionally affiliated with the Hebrew University of Jerusalem or other complicit Israeli academic institutions.

³²Forbes. "Profile: Michael Federmann." (2006). https://www.forbes.com/lists/2006/81/biz_06israel_Michael-Ami-Federmann_U7OT.html. Accessed August 25, 2026. [Note: this is a 2006 profile – consider a more recent source for a claim about current board membership.]

³³Leuphana University Lüneburg. "Leuphana Professor Represents Germany Against Genocide Allegations." (April 12, 2024). <https://www.leuphana.de/en/institutions/faculty/school-of-public-affairs/news/single-view/2024/04/12/leuphana-professor-represents-germany-against-genocide-allegations.html>. Accessed April 12, 2024.

3. Suspend the joint research project between the Institute of Sustainability Psychology at Leuphana and Hebrew University of Jerusalem faculty, and conduct a review of its funding sources and institutional entanglements.
4. Remove the active promotion of the Israel-Lower Saxony Exchange (ILSSE) and the Minerva Foundation from Leuphana's academic advising channels, funding databases, and doctoral support materials, until both programmes have been assessed for compliance with the university's own ethical commitments.
5. Establish a review commission tasked with conducting a full audit of all existing institutional ties to Israeli academic institutions – including those not documented in this report – and publish its findings. This commission should include representatives of the students and workers who have raised these concerns.

Regarding academic freedom and the definition of antisemitism, we make the following demands of the Student Parliament of Leuphana (StuPa):

1. Formally cease the application of the IHRA working definition of antisemitism in any institutional decision-making, including decisions regarding the use of university facilities, approvals, and funding allocations.
2. Adopt the Jerusalem Declaration on Antisemitism (JDA) as the university's working framework for identifying and addressing antisemitism on campus. The JDA offers a rigorous, scholarly definition that protects Jewish students and staff from genuine antisemitism while preserving the right to criticize the policies of the Israeli state and to engage in solidarity with the Palestinian people.
3. Issue a public statement affirming that participation in campaigns for Palestinian rights, including calls for the suspension of institutional ties with complicit Israeli universities, does not constitute antisemitism under any definition applied by Leuphana.
4. Establish connections with Palestinian universities in the occupied West Bank, East Jerusalem, and Gaza.

These demands are grounded in Leuphana's own institutional documents. The university's Sustainability Guidelines require that all external cooperation be evaluated against its mission statement. The mission statement commits Leuphana to humanism, responsibility for future generations, and shaping society towards justice. We are asking the university to comply with its own rules and regulations.

Open Letter to Students, Workers, and Academics of Leuphana

To our fellow students, workers, staff, and academics at Leuphana University Lüneburg,

This report has documented what we believe to be an urgent and unresolved contradiction at the heart of our university. Leuphana presents itself as an institution committed to ethical responsibility, social transformation, and the long-term wellbeing of people and planet. Yet it maintains active institutional ties with academic institutions that are embedded in a military apparatus currently engaged in what the International Court of Justice has described as plausible genocide – one that has killed tens of thousands of civilians, displaced the overwhelming majority of a population, and systematically destroyed every university in Gaza.

We are not asking you to agree with every argument in this report. We are asking you to consider whether the facts it documents – the exchange programme, the visiting fellowship, the joint research project, the promoted funding programmes – are consistent with the university we want to be part of. We believe that they are not. And we believe that saying so, clearly and together, is both possible and necessary.

The criminalization and suppression of this conversation in Germany is a real, existential threat. The Lunatic Festival incident documented in this report shows that even a campus-adjacent cultural institution can be financially coerced into silencing Palestinian and Jewish voices. We are aware that raising these issues carries risks. We raise them anyway, because silence in the face of documented complicity is its own form of participation.

We want to be precise about what we are and are not calling for. We are not calling for the targeting or harassment of any individual researcher, student, or visiting academic. We are calling for Leuphana as an institution to examine and end the formal ties that make it complicit, and to replace a definition of antisemitism that has been used to suppress this conversation with one that takes both antisemitism and Palestinian rights seriously.

If you share these concerns, we invite you to act in whatever way corresponds to your position and possibilities:

- Sign the petition calling on Leuphana to suspend its institutional ties with complicit Israeli academic institutions and conduct a full review.
- Sign the petition calling on Leuphana and StuPa to drop the IHRA definition and adopt the Jerusalem Declaration on Antisemitism in its place.
- Raise these questions in your seminars, thesis committees, departmental meetings, and student body assemblies. The university's own Sustainability Guidelines

³⁴ provide a legitimate institutional basis for doing so.

- Share this report with colleagues, supervisors, and fellow students – within Leuphana and beyond.

What is happening in Gaza is not distant from us. The institutions we study and work within are connected to it. We have the capacity, and we believe the obligation, to make those connections visible and to demand that they end.

In solidarity with all students who have lost their family, university, certificate, mother, son, father, family, or life.

Students4Palestine Lüneburg

³⁴Leuphana University Lüneburg. "Sustainability Guidelines."

<https://www.leuphana.de/en/university/sustainable/sustainability-guidelines.html>. Accessed March 19, 2026.